University of St.Gallen

# Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

# 8,280: Beyond Homo Oeconomicus: Decision Making and Wellbeing in Economics

# ECTS credits: 4

## Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time
central - Written examination, Digital, Individual work individual grade (50%, 90 mins.)
Examination time: Lecture-free period

## Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,280,1.00 Beyond Homo Oeconomicus: Decision Making and Wellbeing in Economics -- English -- Kolmar Martin

## Course information

### Prerequisites

none

### Learning objectives

1. Develop a nuanced understanding of key findings from contemporary psychology and neuroscience related to perception, decision-making, development, and well-being, and cultivate the ability to critically assess their implications.
2. Analyze and evaluate how models of human well-being and decision-making relate to broader conceptions of society and the economy.
3. Critically examine mainstream economic assumptions and frameworks, and explore theoretically and empirically grounded alternatives.
4. Strengthen presentation, communication, and academic debate skills in the context of complex interdisciplinary topics.
5. Enhance the ability to plan, structure, and collaboratively execute effective group work.
6. Foster critical, independent, and analytically rigorous thinking.

### Content

**Course Content**

The purpose of this course is to develop a deep and interdisciplinary understanding of how humans perceive reality, make decisions, develop, and perceive well-being. Because decision theory forms a foundation for modern economics, political science, and business administration, it is essential to understand how decisions are actually formed—and how they relate to individual well-being.

The course consists of three main parts:

**1. Traditional Economic and Behavioral Foundations**
In the first part, we examine the classical economic model of decision-making, focusing on the homo oeconomicus framework of preference maximization and instrumental rationality. We critically analyze the assumptions underlying this model and introduce Behavioral Economics, a field that systematically challenges these assumptions. To contextualize these developments, we adopt a history-of-science perspective, exploring how economics evolved in dialogue with other social sciences and how its epistemic and ontological commitments have shaped its theoretical trajectory.

**2. Evolutionary, Psychological, and Neuroscientific Perspectives**
The second part shifts to an evolutionary and neuroscientific perspective, viewing decisions as the outcomes of layered biological and psychological adaptation mechanisms. These mechanisms have evolved to ensure survival, reproduction, and functional interaction with complex environments. We investigate how these systems operate—and how they give rise to decision-making and subjective well-being—drawing on insights from evolutionary biology, affective and cognitive neuroscience, affective psychology, narrative psychology, and artificial intelligence.

**3. Applications, Presentations, and Societal Implications**
The third part consists of student group presentations. Students will either examine selected topics in greater depth or apply theoretical insights to contemporary societal challenges. This section emphasizes practical implications for economic policy, the role of the state, and broader societal decision-making frameworks.

**Course Overview**

**I. Homo Oeconomicus**

- Anybody home? Revealed preferences and mindless economics
- Rational-choice theories of decision-making
- Behavioral Economics

**II. Humans as Multi-Layered Adaptation Mechanisms**

- Ultimate and proximate causes and the homunculus fallacy
- Genetic and epigenetic adaptation
- Affective calibration
- Consciousness, learning, and the narrative self
- The predictive-brain hypothesis

**III. Towards a Unified Theory of Decision-Making and Well-Being?**

- Some remarks on normative criteria
- Mismatch theories of environment and adaptation
- Implications for Economics, Business Administration, Political Science, and Law

This course provides a comprehensive framework for understanding human decision-making by integrating insights from economics, behavioral sciences, and evolutionary perspectives. It invites students to critically examine existing models, explore alternative conceptualizations, and connect theoretical foundations to contemporary societal questions.

## Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

During the first half of the semester, the course meets weekly and focuses on introducing and discussing key concepts and theories. In the second half, teaching shifts to two block days during the semester break, which are dedicated to exploring selected topics in greater depth through term papers and student presentations. The course is designed as a flexible and open format that encourages creativity, independent thinking, and substantive discussion. Its success will depend strongly on your active participation and engagement.

## Literature

Selected chapters from the book manuscript

**Martin Kolmar (2026): A New Economics of Welfare: Development, Freedom, and Well-Being.**

The manuscript will be made available on Canvas, where you will also find information about the relevant chapters.

## Additional information

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University of St.Gallen

# Examination information

## Examination sub part/s

## 1. Examination sub part (1/2)

### Examination modalities

| | |
|---|---|
| Examination type | Presentation |
| Responsible for organisation | decentral |
| Examination form | Oral examination |
| Examination mode | Analog |
| Time of examination | Term time |
| Examination execution | Asynchronous |
| Examination location | On Campus |
| Grading type | Group work group grade |
| Weighting | 50% |
| Duration | -- |

### Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

### Remark

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### Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

### Supplementary aids

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## 2. Examination sub part (2/2)

### Examination modalities

| | |
|---|---|
| Examination type | Written examination |
| Responsible for organisation | central |
| Examination form | Written exam |
| Examination mode | Digital |
| Time of examination | Lecture-free period |
| Examination execution | Synchronous |
| Examination location | On Campus |
| Grading type | Individual work individual grade |
| Weighting | 50% |
| Duration | 90 mins. |

### Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

### Remark

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## Examination-aid rule

Open Book

Students are free to choose aids, apart from the following restrictions:

- pocket calculator models which are not part of the Texas Instruments TI-30 series, as well as any programmable electronic devices that are capable of communication such as electronic dictionaries, notebooks, tablets, smartphones, headsets, additional screens, etc. are not admissible;
- there is an option for faculty members to explicitly define exceptions under supplementary aids.

Procuring any aids, as well as ensuring their working order, is the exclusive responsibility of students.

## Supplementary aids

The examination will be conducted as a digital examination with the following admissible media:

- **Private notebook** (compulsory) – no tablets!
- **Mains adapter** (compulsory)
- External computer mouse (optional)
- External computer keyboard (optional)

We would like to point out explicitly that the examination cannot be taken with tablets/iPads.

You will need the following for the examination:

- Appliance and system requirements: cf. StudentWeb
- Special software: LockDown Browser
- HSG log-in including access modalities
- WLAN – operational access to Eduroam

Please make sure that

- all the updates have been carried out before the examination.
- In the run-up to digitally conducted examinations, technical tests (mock examinations without grades) are carried out. Participation is urgently required!
- You yourself are responsible for the perfect working order of your appliance, cf. also StudentWeb.
- Keyboard stickers in the language in which the examination is conducted (such as English, German, as well as Arabic, Chinese, Russian, Japanese, etc. in language examinations) are permitted. The stickers must be identical with the original characters of the language concerned.

Any use of additional appliances that are not listed above will be strictly prohibited throughout the examination.

Any necessary actions with another software or additional appliances require the express prior approval of the persons in charge of the examination and are only permitted under supervision.

Any infringement of these rules of conduct may be sanctioned as an infringement of the rules of the University.

## Content

The final grade consists of two components: a written exam (50%) and a group presentation accompanied by a comprehensive slide deck (50%). The presentation topic can be chosen in consultation with the instructor, and a list of suggested topics and foundational readings will be provided as guidance.

The written exam covers all material outlined under “Course Information.”

## Literature

Selected chapters from the book manuscript

**Martin Kolmar (2026): A New Economics of Welfare: Development, Freedom, and Well-Being.**

The manuscript will be made available on Canvas, where you will also find information about the relevant chapters.

## Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).